

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

01 | The Deccan and the Mughals

DECCAN & THE MUGHALS TO 1657 | ORIGINAL STUDY VISUAL

1 1562-1657: entry, resistance, settlement, renewed intervention

2 A connected political economy, not a north/south binary

3 Evidence-led UPSC learning session

Interpretation aid: labels are evidence-led revision prompts, not a substitute for maps or primary sources.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ Loop (18)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Which formulation best captures Akbar's initial Deccan objective?

- A. Obtain recognition of Mughal over-lordship while allowing local rule under conditions
- B. A permanent equality treaty among sovereign states
- C. Immediate provincial annexation of every sultanate
- D. Withdrawal from all western-coast concerns

Answer: A. Explanation: The Rajasthan-style suzerainty model explains why diplomacy preceded selective force.

Q2. Why was Khandesh strategically important?

- A. It was the only source of Deccani horses
- B. Burhanpur and Asirgarh connected routes, markets and a gateway to the plateau
- C. It eliminated the need for siege logistics
- D. It contained the capital of Golconda

Answer: B. Explanation: The closest distractor is 'horse supply'; route and gateway logic is the source-grounded reason.

Q3. The 1596 Ahmadnagar settlement did which of the following?

- A. Transferred Bijapur to Mughal rule
- B. Ended all Nizam Shahi authority
- C. Ceded Berar while recognising Bahadur under Chand Bibi's regency and Mughal suzerainty
- D. Made Ahmadnagar a Mughal province

Answer: C. Explanation: It was a negotiated survival arrangement, not a full conquest.

Q4. The 1597 battle called Sonapat/Supa/Sonpet in the assigned source should be handled how?

- A. As a certain location with a fixed modern spelling
- B. As an unimportant coastal skirmish
- C. As a battle at Sonipat in Haryana
- D. As a Deccan/Berar campaign event whose nomenclature must not be confused with Sonipat

Answer: D. Explanation: Source nomenclature is uncertain; the secure context is the combined Deccani response in Berar.

Q5. Which statement about Chand Bibi is most defensible?

- A. She was a political actor who defended, negotiated and governed under factional constraint
- B. She independently annexed Bijapur
- C. She ended Mughal interest in Berar
- D. She was only a romantic battlefield icon

Answer: A. Explanation: Her Bijapur and Ahmadnagar links make the 'only warrior-queen' description inadequate.

Q6. Akbar's 1600-01 gains are best described as:

- A. The permanent conquest of all Deccan sultanates

- B. A foothold in Ahmadnagar/Balaghat plus Khandesh/Asirgarh, not complete Deccan control
- C. A treaty that made Golconda a Mughal province
- D. A coastal Portuguese alliance

Answer: B. Explanation: The key discriminator is partial control: Bijapur and Golconda still did not submit.

Q7. Malik Ambar should be identified as:

- A. A Maratha king who founded Shivaji's state
- B. A Mughal mansabdar permanently loyal to Jahangir
- C. A Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics who used a multi-group coalition including Maratha cavalry
- D. A Portuguese commander at Surat

Answer: C. Explanation: His Ethiopian/Habshi origin and Nizam Shahi office rule out the Maratha-ruler shortcut.

Q8. Why is 'guerrilla warfare' a cautious label for Ambar's methods?

- A. It means Ambar never used forts or diplomacy
- B. It describes European naval tactics
- C. It proves a modern nationalist insurgency
- D. It is shorthand for mobility and supply disruption, not a modern equivalence

Answer: D. Explanation: The source describes rapid cavalry and supply cutting; present-day political meanings should not be projected backward.

Q9. What is the safest account of Ambar's revenue policy?

- A. Later Marathi evidence attributes measurement and zabti-type changes, but uniform details are uncertain
- B. No revenue policy is associated with him
- C. He copied Todar Mal's system exactly everywhere
- D. It established a modern cash tax state

Answer: A. Explanation: The source limit is the point: attribution is useful without claiming identical, universal reform.

Q10. Jahangir's restraint after 1617 primarily indicates:

- A. That he lacked any army in the Deccan
- B. A deliberate wish to avoid enlarged commitments after recovering Akbar-era gains
- C. That he annexed Bijapur
- D. That Malik Ambar permanently surrendered

Answer: B. Explanation: Satish Chandra explicitly treats restraint as policy rather than simple military failure.

Q11. The painting of Jahangir shooting Malik Ambar's image is best used as:

- A. A report of an actual assassination
- B. A neutral map of Deccan boundaries
- C. Evidence of imperial symbolism and claimed dominance
- D. Proof that Ambar never fought the Mughals

Answer: C. Explanation: A court painting can reveal representation; it cannot be read as literal event reportage.

Q12. Bhaturi (1624) matters because:

- A. It was an English factory treaty
- B. It marked Daulatabad's surrender
- C. It ended all Mughal campaigns in India
- D. It raised Ambar's prestige after victory over a combined Mughal-Adil Shahi force in the source narrative

Answer: D. Explanation: The closest distractor is Daulatabad, but that belongs to 1633 and Shah Jahan's phase.

Q13. The fall of Daulatabad in 1633 demonstrates:

- A. Dynastic extinction did not automatically end local resistance or claimant politics
- B. That Shahji stopped changing service
- C. That Bijapur was annexed
- D. That 1636 terms had already been imposed

Answer: A. Explanation: Shahji's subsequent claimant project shows why fort fall and field control must be separated.

Q14. The 1636 arrangements with Bijapur and Golconda are best classified as:

- A. An equal modern treaty without hierarchy
- B. Coercive Mughal suzerainty/protection leaving buffer states intact
- C. A direct annexation settlement
- D. A Portuguese maritime alliance

Answer: B. Explanation: Khutba, tribute and arbitration denote hierarchy, while the sultanates retained their courts.

Q15. Which is an accurate Golconda term in the assigned source?

- A. Golconda abolished all Persianate links
- B. Golconda ceded every port to the Mughals
- C. Shah Jahan's name entered the khutba while the Iranian sovereign's was removed, alongside tribute/protection
- D. Golconda became a Mughal province in 1636

Answer: C. Explanation: The political signal was changed sovereign recognition, not immediate provincial administration.

Q16. Why was the 1636 settlement statesmanlike in the source's assessment?

- A. It eliminated every local elite network
- B. It stopped all Deccan expansion southward
- C. It required no military pressure
- D. It stabilised a frontier through buffers and hierarchy at lower direct Mughal cost

Answer: D. Explanation: The settlement combined coercion with limited aims; its advantages were strategic and fiscal.

Q17. The 1656-57 interventions should be interpreted as:

- A. A break in the restraint that had sustained the 1636 spirit
- B. A war of succession episode after 1658
- C. A completed later-Aurangzeb conquest
- D. Proof that 1636 had annexed Bijapur and Golconda

Answer: A. Explanation: They undermined the buffer compact before the later succession war and full annexation era.

Q18. Which conclusion best fits the whole topic?

- A. The Deccan was isolated until Mughal armies arrived
- B. Mughal policy was always uniform conquest
- C. Maratha nationalism was created by one person
- D. B. Entry, partial control, mobile resistance, treaty and renewed intervention formed a changing capacity problem

Answer: B. Explanation: This causal sequence explains both imperial gains and the costs of keeping them.

Broad Topic MCQs (40)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Which statement best expresses the principal lesson of north-south connectivity?

- A. A purely coastal relationship
- B. A sealed boundary at the Vindhya
- C. A connected corridor system of trade, migration, pilgrimage and war
- D. No pre-Mughal interaction

Answer: C. Explanation: Long-distance movement preceded the Mughals; the false 'sealed Vindhyan boundary' option erases routes, migration and pilgrimage.

Q2. Which statement best expresses the Faruqi Khandesh location in strategy?

- A. A Golconda port
- B. Burhanpur-Asirgarh gateway to routes and operations
- C. A Maratha capital
- D. A substitute for Berar revenue

Answer: D. Explanation: Burhanpur and Asirgarh mattered as a linked gateway. Horse supply was important in Deccan politics but is not the reason assigned to Khandesh here.

Q3. Which statement best expresses the risk of treating sect as a full explanation?

- A. It makes all alliances easy to predict
- B. It removes factional competition
- C. It proves all Deccan courts were identical
- D. It ignores office, local rivalry and cross-label alliances

Answer: A. Explanation: Sectarian affiliation mattered in some courts, yet office, rivalry and expediency changed partnerships; 'alliance is predictable' is therefore the faulty shortcut.

Q4. Which statement best expresses the 1591 mission outcome?

- A. Khandesh clearly submitted while other responses were limited/courteous
- B. Every court accepted direct annexation
- C. Bijapur became a Mughal province
- D. Portugal joined the Mughals

Answer: B. Explanation: The 1591 missions produced one clear Khandesh acceptance, not annexation or a Portuguese alliance; courtesy elsewhere did not equal submission.

Q5. Which statement best expresses the main political error in a Chand Bibi answer?

- A. Treating her only as a romantic heroine
- B. Not calling Berar a port
- C. Mentioning factionalism
- D. Recognising her negotiation

Answer: C. Explanation: Calling Chand Bibi only a romantic heroine suppresses regency and negotiation; her political work is the exact missing dimension.

Q6. Which statement best expresses the significance of Berar?

- A. It ended Ahmadnagar immediately
- B. It supplied a Mughal foothold that alarmed Deccani neighbours
- C. It was equivalent to all the Deccan
- D. It became a permanent Portuguese base

Answer: D. Explanation: Berar mattered because it supplied a forward Mughal foothold; the claim that it ended Ahmadnagar immediately confuses cession with extinction.

Q7. Which statement best expresses the secure reading of 1600?

- A. Ahmadnagar fort fell but Nizam Shahi resistance continued
- B. Golconda was annexed
- C. Akbar had ceased to intervene
- D. All Nizam Shahi territory was pacified

Answer: A. Explanation: The fort's fall did not exhaust Nizam Shahi legitimacy or territory; the option saying resistance ended ignores the claimant-Ambar recovery.

Q8. Which statement best expresses the source-critical Asirgarh conclusion?

- A. Only a bribery story can be mentioned
- B. Every capture story has identical evidence
- C. Siege/pestilence/surrender are in the assigned account; alternatives need provenance
- D. The fort did not matter

Answer: B. Explanation: The assigned siege-pestilence-surrender narrative can be used, but exclusive reliance on a bribery story ignores the source-critical problem.

Q9. Which statement best expresses Ambar's coalition?

- A. Nizam Shahi legitimacy, Habshis, Deccanis, Bijapur support and Maratha networks
- B. Only Maratha rulers
- C. Only Habshi troops and no allies
- D. Only Portuguese naval aid

Answer: C. Explanation: Ambar's coalition joined legitimacy, Habshi leadership, Bijapuri support and Maratha resources; 'only Maratha rulers' makes the key category error.

Q10. Which statement best expresses a Mughal logistical weakness?

- A. Total absence of cavalry
- B. Lack of forts in India
- C. No access to revenue
- D. Distance, supply, monsoon and command coordination

Answer: D. Explanation: A campaign's supplies, weather and command coherence are concrete constraints; 'absence of cavalry' is neither the source's point nor plausible.

Q11. Which statement best expresses the value of deshmukh networks?

- A. They were irrelevant to revenue or mobilisation
- B. They were European companies
- C. They joined local authority to service and armed following
- D. They ended court faction

Answer: A. Explanation: Deshmukh ties connected local authority with revenue and mobilisation; calling them irrelevant removes the interface that made service networks valuable.

Q12. Which statement best expresses the safe claim about Khirki?

- A. It proves a verified uniform water reform
- B. It is associated with an Ambar-era Nizam Shahi centre
- C. It was a Mughal capital under Akbar
- D. It was founded by Shivaji in 1674

Answer: B. Explanation: Khirki is safely an Ambar-era Nizam Shahi centre; a verified universal water reform is an unsupported escalation from an urban association.

Q13. Which statement best expresses the 1616-17 sequence?

- A. Ambar died
- B. Jahangir annexed every Deccan state
- C. Mughal victories recovered gains, yet did not end resistance
- D. the 1636 treaty occurred

Answer: C. Explanation: The 1616-17 sequence illustrates recovery without final resolution; 'Jahangir annexed every state' makes a limited campaign into total conquest.

Q14. Which statement best expresses Jahangir's farzand language?

- A. A Portuguese title
- B. A declaration of equality without claims
- C. a revenue survey
- D. A diplomatic effort to manage Bijapur within hierarchy

Answer: D. Explanation: Farzand was hierarchical diplomacy aimed at managing Bijapur; it was not a declaration that Mughal claims had vanished.

Q15. Which statement best expresses the 1621 cycle?

- A. Shows repeated military pressure and unstable settlements
- B. Creates the Nizam Shahi dynasty
- C. Shows a final peace after 1596
- D. occurs after 1636

Answer: A. Explanation: The 1621 cycle belongs to recurring pressure and unstable settlement; it cannot be treated as a final peace after 1596.

Q16. Which statement best expresses the balanced Ambar assessment?

- A. Resistance/state reconstruction alongside shifting alliances and inability to save Ahmadnagar permanently
- B. Only heroism; no political limits
- C. Only betrayal; no achievement
- D. A simple modern nationalist story

Answer: B. Explanation: Ambar's reconstruction and resistance were real, but permanent survival failed; the 'only heroism' option loses the necessary limitation.

Q17. Which statement best expresses Shahji's historical value here?

- A. He is interchangeable with Shivaji
- B. He ended all Bijapuri links
- C. He illustrates shifting service and claimant politics
- D. He was an independent Mughal emperor

Answer: C. Explanation: Shahji demonstrates shifting service and claimant politics; he was neither a Mughal emperor nor a static opponent of every court.

Q18. Which statement best expresses the primary aim of Shah Jahan's early policy?

- A. Return Berar
- B. Give up Khandesh
- C. Annex every southern state immediately
- D. Extinguish Ahmadnagar as a persistent source of instability

Answer: D. Explanation: Shah Jahan's early target was Ahmadnagar as an unresolved security problem, not immediate absorption of all southern kingdoms.

Q19. Which statement best expresses the Daulatabad result?

- A. Nizam Shahi dynastic end in 1633 but not instant social/military pacification

- B. the 1657 settlement
- C. Mughal departure from Khandesh
- D. Golconda annexed in 1633

Answer: A. Explanation: Daulatabad ended the dynasty but did not dissolve resistance; equating the event with Golconda's annexation is a chronology and category error.

Q20. Which statement best expresses Bijapur's 1636 relation to Golconda?

- A. a union of the two states
- B. Non-interference plus future imperial arbitration
- C. withdrawal from Karnataka
- D. Full annexation of Golconda

Answer: B. Explanation: Bijapur's promise of non-interference and arbitration arranged relations with Golconda; it did not empower Bijapur to annex it.

Q21. Which statement best expresses the political import of khutba/sikka?

- A. They automatically prove modern citizenship
- B. They are only artistic forms
- C. They can signal hierarchy and sovereign recognition
- D. They end local administration

Answer: C. Explanation: Khutba and sikka indicate recognised hierarchy in political language; they do not automatically create modern citizenship or erase administration.

Q22. Which statement best expresses the buffer-state argument?

- A. It guarantees loyalty forever
- B. It is annexation
- C. It removes all need for diplomacy
- D. It can lower direct administrative costs while sustaining hierarchy

Answer: D. Explanation: Buffers could transmit tribute and hierarchy at less direct cost; their value is not a guarantee of permanent loyalty.

Q23. Which statement best expresses post-1636 southern expansion?

- A. Bijapur and Golconda expanded into Karnataka under treaty space
- B. The Deccan became economically inactive
- C. Europeans controlled all internal routes
- D. Mughals directly ruled every southern town

Answer: A. Explanation: Post-1636 southern campaigns by the buffer states are central; the claim of economic inactivity reverses the treaty-space consequence.

Q24. Which statement best expresses the use of European commercial reports?

- A. Treat them as neutral nationwide census
- B. Use them with a coastal/commercial provenance caution
- C. Use them to prove every fort capture
- D. Ignore all Mughal sources

Answer: B. Explanation: European commercial reports must be read through their coastal-commercial lens, not treated as a neutral census of inland Deccan.

Q25. Which statement best expresses the 1656 Golconda trigger?

- A. a 1591 embassy
- B. A mature Shivaji treaty
- C. A mix of tribute/exchange, compensation and Mir Jumla context

- D. Daulatabad's 1633 siege

Answer: C. Explanation: Golconda intervention combined tribute/exchange and compensation claims with the Mir Jumla setting; it is not a retrospective Shivaji episode.

Q26. Which statement best expresses the 1657 Bijapur crisis?

- A. It came after Aurangzeb's 1687 conquest
- B. It ended the war of succession
- C. Direct annexation had already been completed
- D. Muhammad Adil Shah's death and Mughal claims enabled pressure

Answer: D. Explanation: Muhammad Adil Shah's death created a usable Bijapur crisis; full annexation had not already occurred and would belong to later history.

Q27. Which statement best expresses Shah Jahan's late aims?

- A. They were contested and could fall short of Aurangzeb's full-annexation ambition
- B. They are known only from European reports
- C. They never involved territory
- D. They were proven identical to Aurangzeb's

Answer: A. Explanation: The source separates Aurangzeb's expansive preference from Shah Jahan's variable aims; asserting identity erases that policy debate.

Q28. Which statement best expresses the state-capacity causal loop?

- A. Sect -> automatic annexation
- B. Factional opening -> foothold -> resistance -> costly partial control -> treaty -> renewed intervention
- C. Trade -> no politics
- D. Conquest -> permanent peace without cost

Answer: B. Explanation: The causal loop includes resistance and treaty after entry; the 'permanent peace' alternative misses why 1656-57 mattered.

Q29. Which statement best expresses the right overextension conclusion by 1657?

- A. No fiscal issue existed
- B. The Mughal Empire had ended
- C. A growing risk and process, not an already inevitable completed collapse
- D. The Deccan had no effect on administration

Answer: C. Explanation: By 1657 overextension was a developing risk, not an empire already ended; the answer must preserve this temporal distinction.

Q30. Which statement best expresses a limitation of Persian court chronicles?

- A. They have no chronology at all
- B. They can never be used
- C. They are European coastal sources
- D. Patronage can privilege imperial success and hierarchy

Answer: D. Explanation: Court patronage can encourage a success narrative, not make Persian chronicles worthless; the latter is an overcorrection.

Q31. Which statement best expresses a limitation of later bakhars?

- A. Retrospection and local loyalty require provenance checks
- B. They are automatically fabricated
- C. They are all contemporary battle maps
- D. They are Mughal farmans

Answer: A. Explanation: Later bakhars can preserve useful local memory, but retrospective loyalty requires checking; automatic fabrication is not method.

Q32. Which statement best expresses a material source contribution?

- A. They prove every motive
- B. Forts, inscriptions, coins and water works can complement texts
- C. They make texts unnecessary
- D. They have no chronology

Answer: B. Explanation: Material remains complement texts by locating claims in forts, coins and works; they do not remove the need for textual comparison.

Q33. Which statement best expresses a memory/history distinction?

- A. Only nationalist frames matter
- B. Memory must always replace evidence
- C. Heroic remembrance can coexist with evidence-based qualification
- D. Sources have no genre

Answer: C. Explanation: Remembrance can illuminate why a figure matters, but it cannot replace evidence; the correct option combines both rather than choosing one.

Q34. Which statement best expresses the Topic 18 boundary?

- A. Narrate Aurangzeb to 1707 fully
- B. End at Talikota
- C. Ignore Maratha bridge
- D. Stop at 1657 and route later annexation/mature Shivaji to later topics

Answer: D. Explanation: Topic 18 ends at 1657, so later Aurangzeb and mature Shivaji material is a route, not its narrative endpoint.

Q35. Which statement best expresses the best Mains structure?

- A. Thesis, named evidence, causal analysis, qualification and verdict
- B. A date list alone
- C. A single heroic anecdote
- D. Unqualified generalisation

Answer: A. Explanation: A direct thesis plus evidence, analysis and qualification answers an unfamiliar directive; a date list offers no causal judgement.

Q36. Which statement best expresses the function of forts?

- A. They make diplomacy redundant
- B. They are nodes in route-market-logistics systems, not decorative points
- C. They belong only to culture
- D. They remove all supply needs

Answer: B. Explanation: Forts are strategic nodes because they relate to corridors, markets and supplies; treating them as decorations loses their operational function.

Q37. Which statement best expresses the significance of Burhanpur?

- A. It was Golconda's port
- B. It was outside Khandesh
- C. It was a capital/gateway and provisioning-commercial node
- D. It did not matter to campaigns

Answer: C. Explanation: Burhanpur combined capital/gateway/provisioning functions; it was not Golconda's port and cannot be omitted from Khandesh strategy.

Q38. Which statement best expresses the distinction between occupation and annexation?

- A. Occupation is a cultural term
- B. They always mean the same thing
- C. Annexation means only tribute
- D. An occupied fort can precede or differ from durable administrative incorporation

Answer: D. Explanation: Occupation can be militarily real before administration is durable; the options treating it as identical to annexation or mere culture fail.

Q39. Which statement best expresses the prerequisite for claiming a direct PYQ?

- A. Exact verified wording and provenance
- B. A coaching recollection
- C. A similar generic Deccan geography question
- D. A mature Shivaji question

Answer: A. Explanation: A direct PYQ requires exact wording and provenance; similarity to generic geography or a coaching recollection is not verification.

Q40. Which statement best expresses the correct closing boundary?

- A. Topic 18 must narrate events through Aurangzeb's death
- B. The 1656-57 crisis is analysed, then later full annexation and mature Shivaji conflict are routed forward
- C. The narrative ends at 1636 because treaties never changed
- D. The 1657 events are irrelevant to later dilemmas

Answer: B. Explanation: The 1656-57 breach is the final analysed event because it creates, rather than completes, the later Deccan dilemma; the alternatives either overrun or truncate the set boundary.

Remedial MCQs (12)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Did Akbar conquer the whole Deccan?

- A. Yes, by the 1591 missions
- B. Yes, in 1601
- C. No. His gains were important but partial: Khandesh, Berar/Balaghat and Ahmadnagar fort did not equal Bijapur/Golconda submission.
- D. A. No: he secured a foothold, not the whole Deccan

Answer: C. Explanation: Yes, through 1636

Q2. What is wrong with a 'warrior-queen only' account of Chand Bibi?

- A. It hides regency, factional management, correspondence and negotiation under pressure.
- B. It overstates her links with Bijapur
- C. B. It erases her political agency beyond battlefield memory
- D. She had no political role

Answer: D. Explanation: It makes Berar too important

Q3. Was Malik Ambar a Maratha ruler?

- A. He was a Mughal prince
- B. No. He was a Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics who mobilised Maratha military networks.
- C. C. No: coalition leadership is not the same as Maratha rulership
- D. He was Shahji

Answer: A. Explanation: He was a Portuguese captain

Q4. Does 'guerrilla' mean modern insurgency here?

- A. It describes a twentieth-century ideology
- B. It proves nationalism
- C. It excludes diplomacy
- D. No. It is a limited analytic label for mobility, terrain and supply disruption.

Answer: B. Explanation: D. No: it is shorthand, not a modern equivalence

Q5. Did 1636 annex Bijapur and Golconda?

- A. Yes, because tribute equals province
- B. A. No: suzerainty/protection is not direct annexation
- C. No. The arrangements imposed hierarchy, tribute/protection and arbitration while leaving buffer states intact.
- D. Yes, because of khutba alone

Answer: C. Explanation: Yes, because of later wars

Q6. Did Shah Jahan always seek full Deccan conquest?

- A. No. His early policy was bounded by Ahmadnagar; later objectives became more expansive and contested.
- B. B. No: aims changed from a bounded settlement to later demands
- C. He annexed all states in 1633
- D. He never intervened

Answer: D. Explanation: He left all claims to Bijapur

Q7. Was Jahangir's Deccan policy simple military failure?

- A. He ended all campaigns
- B. No. Satish Chandra treats post-success restraint as a deliberate avoidance of deeper commitments.
- C. He had no commanders
- D. C. No: deliberate restraint followed recovery of gains

Answer: A. Explanation: He had no interest in hierarchy

Q8. Is Sonapat/Sonpet the Haryana city Sonapat?

- A. It is a Portuguese port
- B. It is Daulatabad
- C. No. The source's variable name belongs to a Deccan/Berar campaign and must be locationally cautioned.
- D. Yes, it is the Haryana city

Answer: B. Explanation: D. No: do not convert source nomenclature into a false modern location

Q9. Did Ahmadnagar fort's fall end resistance?

- A. Yes, all territory surrendered
- B. A. No: state capacity persisted beyond the fort
- C. No. Claimants, mobile forces and local networks continued after a fort/dynastic centre fell.
- D. Yes, Shahji vanished

Answer: C. Explanation: Yes, Bijapur was annexed

Q10. Did one person create Maratha nationalism?

- A. Shah Jahan created it
- B. B. No: avoid a one-man nationalist origin story
- C. No. Ambar, Shahji and later Shivaji belong to different stages of employment, networks and state formation.
- D. Ambar alone created it

Answer: D. Explanation: The Portuguese created it

Q11. Were Deccan alliances simply Sunni versus Shia?

- A. They had no sectarian dimension
- B. C. No: sect mattered, but never explains the whole field alone
- C. They were always sectarian
- D. No. Office, faction, rivalry and strategic interest repeatedly crossed religious/ethnic labels.

Answer: A. Explanation: Only Europeans chose alliances

Q12. Do 1657 events belong to the later full Aurangzeb wars?

- A. They settle the Deccan permanently
- B. They are unrelated to the 1636 compact
- C. They are after 1687
- D. They are the boundary and bridge: they reopened the dilemma but precede the succession war and later annexations.

Answer: B. Explanation: D. They are a pre-succession spillover, not the later-war narrative

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART V - PYQ AUDIT, ROUTING AND PRACTICE

Transparent PYQ audit: 2018-2025 CSE

Audit result: No direct, exact and verifiably worded CSE Prelims or GS-I question for 2018-2025 was located in the repository's official/OCR/routing material on Mughal Deccan policy, Chand Bibi, Ahmadnagar, Malik Ambar, Khandesh/Asirgarh, Bijapur/Golconda, the 1636 treaties or early Maratha military groups.

This is a **PYQ gap**, not permission to invent a question, invent a key, or misroute a generic Deccan Plateau question. Mature Shivaji/Maratha questions belong primarily to Topic 23; broad Mughal administration questions belong to Topics 16/21; Qandahar belongs to Topic 19. No external/coaching wording is reproduced here as a CSE PYQ. If a future official paper is added, preserve original option order and label an absent official key as **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED** with source, confidence and elimination.

Adjacent routes (not direct Topic 18 PYQs)

Route	Owner	Why it is adjacent, not duplicated
Bahmani break-up, Deccani-afaqi setting, Talikota	Topic 09	Background political field; do not repeat its full Vijayanagara/Bahmani content
Akbar's northern consolidation and late expansion	Topic 15	Provides bridge to Khandesh/Deccan; Topic 18 owns the detailed southern policy
Qandahar/Safavid balance	Topic 19	Parallel frontier policy; use only for comparison of strategy and resources
Jahangir court and Nur Jahan	Topic 20	Court context; Topic 18 owns the Deccan command/policy analysis
Shah Jahan/mansabdari and jagir strain	Topic 21	Fiscal architecture; Topic 18 owns Deccan application and settlement
Aurangzeb's later wars	Topic 22	Outside the 1657 boundary
Shivaji, mature Maratha state and later Deccan crisis	Topic 23	Topic 18 supplies only the pre-Shivaji bridge

Current-affairs verification

No material recent official current-affairs anchor found; static and heritage relevance retained. A live official/UNESCO search covering 18 February-18 August 2026 found the UNESCO Tentative List description of *Monuments and Forts of the Deccan Sultanate* but no date-specific official conservation, status or policy development materially linked to this topic in the requested period. It is therefore heritage context, not a forced current-affairs card.

Static teaching link: History -> Medieval India -> Deccan Sultanates, route systems, state capacity and heritage-source method.

Examiner-grade Original Mains Practice (10 solved answers)

Mains 1. 10 marks | Examine the motives and evolution of Mughal policy in the Deccan up to 1636. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: explain motives and change, not a list of battles.

Model solution: Mughal policy evolved from an all-India claim of hierarchy toward selective force and a low-cost settlement. Akbar's 1591 missions show that over-lordship was first sought by diplomacy; Khandesh's response, unlike the limited courtesy elsewhere, gave a corridor foothold. The Burhanpur-Asirgarh route and Gujarat-Surat connection made security and commerce material motives, while Deccani factionalism offered opportunities. The 1596 Berar cession and 1600-01 gains secured positions but did not create full rule: Bijapur and Golconda remained outside submission, and Ahmadnagar resistance revived.

Jahangir recovered gains but, after Khurram's 1617 campaign, deliberately avoided enlarged commitments. Shah Jahan then treated independent Ahmadnagar as the unresolved source of instability, ended its dynasty at Daulatabad (1633), and used the 1636 ahdnamas to make Bijapur and Golconda accept suzerainty. Thus policy was neither a timeless conquest drive nor mere glory: it balanced hierarchy, security, routes and cost. **Qualification:** military pressure made the settlement coercive, not an equal compact.

Why this earns marks: It answers evolution with four named anchors and distinguishes suzerainty from annexation.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Mains 1. 10 marks | Examine the motives and evolution of Mughal policy in the Deccan up to...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 1. 10 marks | Examine the motives and evolution of Mughal policy in the Deccan up to...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 2. 10 marks | Assess Chand Bibi's role in the Ahmadnagar crisis of 1595-1600. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: assess agency within constraints rather than write a heroic biography.

Model solution: Chand Bibi was a political actor whose agency was real but constrained by succession conflict and imperial pressure. After Burhan Nizam Shah's death and Ibrahim's death in war, Miyan Manju backed a pretender while Chand Bibi, linked to both Ahmadnagar and Bijapur, supported infant Bahadur with the Habshi party. Her defence during the 1595-96 siege, appeal for support and acceptance of the Berar settlement show command, diplomacy and regency rather than a merely romantic warrior image.

The settlement preserved Bahadur under her guardianship but conceded Berar and Mughal suzerainty. It was a survival bargain made amid a strong Bijapur-Golconda presence, not proof of free choice. Later noble divisions, disputes over Berar and the combined response in 1597 made the arrangement untenable. During the second siege she explored a subordinate settlement for Bahadur and was killed by a hostile faction on a charge of treachery.

Verdict: Chand Bibi delayed collapse and displayed political judgement, but could not overcome the internal fragmentation that enabled Mughal intervention.

Why this earns marks: It integrates succession, treaty, agency and factional qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Mains 2. 10 marks | Assess Chand Bibi's role in the Ahmadnagar crisis of 1595-1600. Answer...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 2. 10 marks | Assess Chand Bibi's role in the Ahmadnagar crisis of 1595-1600. Answer...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 3. 10 marks | Explain why Khandesh and Asirgarh mattered more than as mere conquests. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: explain strategic function through geography and logistics.

Model solution: Khandesh was a gateway system, not a decorative northern edge of the Deccan. Its capital Burhanpur lay on the corridor linking northern Mughal power to the plateau and on the Agra-Surat/western trade route. Asirgarh, reputed a formidable fort, protected access to this route-and-market complex. Their capture in 1601 therefore gave the Mughals a base for provisioning, movement, intelligence and pressure on Deccani states.

The point is demonstrated by the contrast with Ahmadnagar: capturing a fort did not itself create durable regional control, whereas a corridor could sustain campaigns only if routes, supplies and allies remained available. Satish Chandra's account of siege, pestilence and surrender supports the capture narrative; competing traditions should be marked source-dependent. **Qualification:** Khandesh reduced entry costs but did not solve monsoon, distance, local resistance or command coordination. Thus it enabled a foothold, not automatic mastery of the entire Deccan.

Why this earns marks: It uses Burhanpur, Asirgarh and the route-supply mechanism instead of a bare location fact.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Mains 3. 10 marks | Explain why Khandesh and Asirgarh mattered more than as mere conquests...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 3. 10 marks | Explain why Khandesh and Asirgarh mattered more than as mere conquests...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 4. 15 marks | Evaluate Malik Ambar as both a defender of Ahmadnagar and a maker of Deccan political possibilities. Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: evaluate achievement, mechanism and limitation.

Model solution: Malik Ambar defended Nizam Shahi survival by converting fragmented resources into a working coalition, while his methods widened the political space available to Maratha military elites. An Ethiopian/Habshi who rose through Deccan service, he became chief minister/regent for a Nizam Shahi claimant and drew together Habshi leadership, disbanded Deccani soldiers, Bijapuri support at key moments, Maratha bargis and local deshमुख links. By about 1610, this coalition had reversed Akbar's recent gains in the assigned account.

His military method used rapid cavalry, terrain, intelligence and attacks on supplies. It exposed Mughal vulnerabilities of distance, monsoon, forage, siege needs and divided commands; the failed 1611 converging operation is evidence. Later Marathi evidence also attributes measurement, rates and limits on ijara to him, suggesting state reconstruction, though it cannot establish a uniform Todar Mal copy. Bhaturi (1624) demonstrates his peak prestige.

Yet Ambar did not permanently secure Ahmadnagar. His shifting alliances, conflict with Bijapur and refusal to stabilise settlements weakened a united front; Shah Jahan ended the dynasty in 1633. **Verdict:** he was neither a simple national precursor nor only an adventurer: he was an exceptional coalition-builder whose success delayed consolidation and developed regional military capacity, but could not settle the structural contest.

Why this earns marks: It treats origin respectfully, names evidence and balances recovery with failure.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Mains 4. 15 marks | Evaluate Malik Ambar as both a defender of Ahmadnagar and a maker of...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 4. 15 marks | Evaluate Malik Ambar as both a defender of Ahmadnagar and a maker of...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 5. 15 marks | How did mobile warfare expose limits in Mughal state capacity in the Deccan? Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: connect military method to capacity rather than call every raid guerrilla warfare.

Model solution: Mobile warfare did not prove that Mughal arms were ineffective; it showed that battlefield victory and durable control required different capacities. Ambar's forces used rapid mounted movement, local intelligence, terrain and supply-cutting, often avoiding a set battle on unfavourable terms. Satish Chandra associates this mode with Maratha bargis and notes that Mughals were less accustomed to it. The result was delay, re-routing and higher cost for imperial columns dependent on grain, fodder, pay, messages and siege stores.

Distance from northern bases, monsoon conditions and the fort-route-market system magnified this effect. The 1611 plan of Khan Jahan Lodi and Abdullah Khan shows a second weakness: mutual wrangling and failed coordination could undo numerical strength. Conversely, the 1616-17 Mughal successes show that alliances, capable command and concentrated pressure could recover territory. Thus the argument is not environmental determinism.

Qualification: 'guerrilla' is a cautious analytic shorthand, not a modern insurgency label. **Verdict:** the Deccan tested logistics, jagir-backed military resources, command integration and local alliances; it made conquest possible but consolidation contingent and expensive.

Why this earns marks: It gives a causal mechanism, named campaign evidence and a conceptual caution.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Mains 5. 15 marks | How did mobile warfare expose limits in Mughal state capacity in the...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 5. 15 marks | How did mobile warfare expose limits in Mughal state capacity in the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 6. 15 marks | Discuss the pre-Shivaji Maratha bridge without reading later nationalism backward. Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: explain continuity and discontinuity.

Model solution: Pre-Shivaji Maratha power developed through service, local authority and regional competition rather than a ready-made nationalist programme. Deccani courts employed Maratha bargis as mobile cavalry and relied on deshmuks networks that joined landed influence, revenue claims and armed followers. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and Mughal courts all offered office and jagir, allowing families to shift service in response to opportunity and threat.

Malik Ambar's coalition created employment, military experience and confidence for such groups, but he was a Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics, not a Maratha ruler. Shahji Bhonsale illustrates the bridge: he moved among Nizam

Shahi, Mughal and Bijapuri contexts; the assigned source places a 5000 mansab and Poona jagirs in a particular Shah Jahan episode, while later claimant resistance operated with Bijapuri support. These are networks of service, not proof of permanent loyalty.

Qualification: local roots did not automatically yield a sovereign state, and later Shivaji's fort politics, legitimacy and administration need separate analysis. **Verdict:** the bridge explains resources and political learning; it should not erase contingency, diverse actors or the later distinctness of Maratha state formation.

Why this earns marks: It uses bargis, desh mukhs and Shahji while explicitly policing anachronism.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 6. 15 marks | Discuss the pre-Shivaji Maratha bridge without reading later...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 6. 15 marks | Discuss the pre-Shivaji Maratha bridge without reading later...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 7. 15 marks | Was Jahangir's Deccan policy a failure? Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: assess both reverses and stated policy.

Model solution: Jahangir's Deccan record contains reverses, but describing it as simple failure misses a deliberate limited policy. Malik Ambar's recovery by 1610, Prince Parvez's inability to settle the contest and the 1611 command failure reveal the difficulty of consolidating Akbar's gains. Yet Khan-i-Khanan's alliance work and the 1616 victory over a combined Deccani force, followed by Prince Khurram's 1617 campaign, recovered Balaghat and brought the Ahmadnagar fort key.

Satish Chandra stresses that Jahangir did not enlarge Akbar's conquests after these successes because he sought to avoid deeper commitments and hoped moderation would stabilise neighbouring states. Diplomatic efforts to detach Bijapur, including farzand language, supported this design. This is a strategic choice with a cost: Malik Ambar resumed resistance and the political field remained unsettled; Bhatari in 1624 exposed how quickly alliances could change.

Qualification: restraint did not erase logistical or fiscal constraints, and 'deliberate policy' should not become a claim that campaigns were easy. **Verdict:** Jahangir achieved limited recovery and wisely avoided annexation, but could not turn partial military success into a durable regional settlement.

Why this earns marks: It answers the evaluative directive using reverses, victories and the historian's policy interpretation.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Mains 7. 15 marks | Was Jahangir's Deccan policy a failure? Answer in 200 words.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 7. 15 marks | Was Jahangir's Deccan policy a failure? Answer in 200 words.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 8. 20 marks | Examine the 1636 Deccan settlement as a statesmanlike yet coercive system. Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: explain terms, system, benefits and limits.

Model solution: The 1636 settlement was statesmanlike because it replaced an expensive pursuit of direct expansion with a hierarchical buffer system; it was coercive because force and the extinction of Ahmadnagar structured the bargaining power. Shah Jahan had first ended the Nizam Shahi dynasty at Daulatabad in 1633, removing the principal unresolved northern-Deccan rival. He then did not annex Bijapur or Golconda.

Bijapur recognised Mughal suzerainty, paid an indemnity, promised non-interference in Golconda, accepted imperial arbitration of future disputes and agreed to cooperate in reducing Shahji or employ him away from the frontier. It received territory from Ahmadnagar. Golconda placed Shah Jahan's name in the khutba, removed the Iranian sovereign's name, accepted tribute and received Mughal protection. These terms display hierarchy without the province-level administration of direct annexation.

The arrangement lowered direct Mughal cost, stabilised the frontier and allowed Bijapur and Golconda to expand southward into Karnataka. It also gave the emperor an arbiter's role. However, the same ambiguity contained risk: tribute, protection and arbitration could be reinterpreted as claims to compensation and territorial extraction. The states retained military resources, courts and regional ambitions; they were buffers, not inert dependencies.

Qualification: no exact sum should be supplied without the treaty source, and khutba/sikka recognition alone must not be equated with total control. **Verdict:** 1636 was a pragmatic apex of limited imperialism, but its coercive hierarchy and unclear future limits made it vulnerable to the late 1650s reversal.

Why this earns marks: It explains both ahdnamas through a suzerainty-annexation distinction and reaches a graded conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Mains 8. 20 marks | Examine the 1636 Deccan settlement as a statesmanlike yet coercive...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 8. 20 marks | Examine the 1636 Deccan settlement as a statesmanlike yet coercive...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 9. 20 marks | Analyse why the 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem. Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: trace breakdown from settlement to dilemma and stop at 1657.

Model solution: The 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem because they abandoned the restraint that made the 1636 buffer settlement workable. In the decade after 1636, Bijapur and Golconda expanded southward, while the Mughals sometimes maintained neutrality and arbitrated disputes. By the late 1640s, Mughal financial strains in the Deccan, demands for a share of southern gains and the wish to draw powerful servants such as Shahji or Mir Jumla into imperial service altered incentives.

Against Golconda, dispute over tribute/exchange rates and compensation became a pretext for intervention in the Mir Jumla context. Against Bijapur, Muhammad Adil Shah's death, alleged arrears and political disorder opened a crisis. Aurangzeb pressed for more extensive annexation, whereas Shah Jahan's objectives were more variable; the source finds no conclusive basis for resolving every claim about Dara's role. The 1657 result compelled Bijapur to yield former Ahmadnagar areas, while Golconda faced demands over Karnataka-linked claims.

This was more than a campaign sequence: it told buffer states that protection could turn into extraction. It undermined trust, widened Mughal ambition and made a 'union of hearts' psychologically difficult in J. N. Sarkar's formulation.

Qualification: do not narrate the later succession war or Aurangzeb's full Deccan wars as though completed here.

Verdict: Shah Jahan inherited a settlement he had made workable, but late intervention converted its ambiguity into a longer dilemma of annexation versus cost.

Why this earns marks: It links finance, strategy, political debate and treaty credibility within the stipulated end date.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Mains 9. 20 marks | Analyse why the 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 9. 20 marks | Analyse why the 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10. 20 marks | How should historians use sources to assess Mughal state capacity in the Deccan? Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: discuss method and apply it to capacity, not merely list sources.

Model solution: Mughal state capacity in the Deccan is best reconstructed by triangulation because each source type records a different claim rather than the whole field. Mughal Persian chronicles show how emperors represented hierarchy, victory and benevolent order; Abul Fazl's universal sovereignty language and Jahangir's court perspective are crucial, but court patronage can compress resistance. Deccani Persian histories recover rival courts and negotiations; Ferishta-like boundary claims need provenance rather than automatic cartographic acceptance.

Marathi records and later bakhars illuminate deshmukhs, revenue memories and mobile service networks. The attribution of measurement and zabti-type arrangements to Malik Ambar is valuable evidence of remembered state reconstruction, but later retrospective testimony cannot prove exact uniform assessment or a direct Todar Mal copy. Portuguese, Dutch and English reports help with ports, textiles and diplomacy yet privilege coastal commerce over inland command.

Material evidence checks narratives: Asirgarh and Daulatabad explain why siege and route control mattered; coins and khutba language illuminate sovereign claims; inscriptions and water systems can test urban or administrative assertions. Jahangir shooting Ambar's image should be read as imperial symbolism, not an event report.

Qualification: no source is discarded simply for bias; bias identifies purpose. **Verdict:** capacity was uneven and relational - strong enough to take forts and impose hierarchy, but dependent on supplies, local allies and credible settlements - a conclusion available only when textual claims are tested against one another and material settings.

Why this earns marks: It moves from genre to what it can/cannot prove and then applies the method to the historical argument.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Mains 10. 20 marks | How should historians use sources to assess Mughal state capacity in...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

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